

The Clock is TICKING

After its poor show in the Lok Sabha polls, the NCP is at its most vulnerable. Despite holding plum portfolios, the party has little to show. And now it is faced with a resurgent Congress that will dictate terms.

| By Malini Bhupta and Aditi Pai |

After 10 years, the Congress is back to playing Big Brother with Sharad Pawar's Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) in Maharashtra. The Congress's strong showing has taken the wind out of Pawar's out-sized political ambitions. Of the 26 seats it contested, the Grand Old Party walked away with 17, bagging 19.6 per cent of the state's total vote-share, while the NCP, after all the hoopla,

managed to win only eight of the 22 constituencies it contested. The party's share has now slid to seven after the arrest of its Osmanabad MP Padamsinh Patil. To make matters worse, the party has been drubbed in its own stronghold of western Maharashtra. Its loss of key seats like Kolhapur, Hatkanangale, Shirur and Maval only highlights the party's waning influence. Explains Union Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh: "The

NCP LEADERS AT A PRESS CONFERENCE



Report CARD How the NCP ministers have performed



AJIT PAWAR

PORTFOLIO Irrigation, Water Resources

SCORE CARD In 2008, the Centre cleared the Rs 7,777-crore Gosi-

khurd Irrigation Project for Vidarbha, which has seen little progress. A shortage of Rs 4,810 crore means 422 projects are stuck. Goes easy on irrigation after opening up to the private sector.

WORK IN PROGRESS: The Government has managed to irrigate only 3.91 mha of the 8.5 mha of irrigable land.



DILIP WALSE-PATIL

PORTFOLIO Finance, Planning

SCORE CARD Left the power ministry in a sorry state. Given

the lack of time and experience, he will be unable to reign in the state's fiscal deficit. The state is reeling under an annual interest burden of Rs 14,351 crore.

WORK IN PROGRESS: To curb the soaring deficit, which has now touched 3.3 per cent of the state's GDP.



GANESH NAIK

PORTFOLIO Excise, Environment

SCORE CARD During his tenure, excise accounted for 11 per

cent of the total taxes. In 2001, the state gave a 10 year excise duty relief to the wine industry. Has increased the excise duty to 25 per cent on imported liquor.

WORK IN PROGRESS: Is yet to work out a strategy to protect the mangroves and water bodies in the state from pollution.